The decision to replace Mistry as chairman was not taken in a hurry. It was preceded by years of carefully weighing options and embracing steps to support Mistry professionally and persuading him to uphold the group's core ethical values. The first of these steps was taken even before Mistry had completed one year in office.

Nitin Nohria, the tenth dean of Harvard Business School (2010–20), recalls that Mistry's performance and leadership had drawn attention. Within a year, Ratan realized that the new incumbent was not able to rise to his new responsibilities. He tried to find ways of extending support. The person chosen to do so was Nohria, whom Ratan persuaded to join the Tata Sons board as a nominee of Tata Trusts in September 2013.

Ratan gave Mistry 'the opportunity to be surrounded by people that he could leverage and make some use of', says Nohria. He remembers Ratan telling him, 'Nitin, you have one job, and that job is to see if there's any way in which you can help him [Mistry] be successful … I think it's more awkward for me because I'm not gone, I don't want to be engaged, I want to see if I can help Mr Mistry by giving him people whose judgement at first may have a broader perspective and who may be closer in age to him so that he might be open to their suggestions.' He says that what 'most people will never understand is that he [Ratan] had only one wish when he asked me to serve', to make Mistry 'successful'. Ratan told him: We've chosen this person, he's very smart, he's very capable, but he is a little less experienced, and I want you to serve so that you can help him be successful. 'Nothing would please me more than if he [Mistry] ends up being an extraordinarily successful leader on behalf of Tata Sons.'

While efforts were being taken to help Mistry perform better, the issue of conflict of interest continued to fester. The new chairman kept dithering on one pretext or the other. His refrain was that he had tasked his staff to recommend a viable solution.

Ratan initially accepted this explanation. But as months rolled into years without any tangible progress, he began to have doubts about Mistry's sincerity to follow through with his commitments.

The issue attained greater importance as Mistry's family concern began bagging more contracts from various Tata companies, mainly from TCS, IHCL and Tata Motors. Since Mistry had been appointed as deputy chairman, during the sixteen months beginning 2012–13, his family concern had bagged contracts worth over Rs 1,136 crore from Tata companies. It